

Australia's economy relies on strong, open trade. Every day, we import a range of live animals, plants and animal and plant products.

We must determine if an animal, plant or animal/plant product is safe to import to Australia. This is because imported goods can carry serious pests and diseases. We make this decision by assessing these biosecurity risks in the form of an import risk analysis.

Why we conduct import risk analyses

Import risk analyses are a key part of Australia's biosecurity system. This system protects Australia against the entry, establishment and spread of pests and diseases.

Australia is a member of the World Trade Organization (WTO). The WTO's primary purpose is to ensure safe and open trade for the benefit of all its member countries. Under our WTO obligations, we must consider import requests from our trading partners.

However, we are entitled to maintain a level of protection we consider appropriate to prevent pests and diseases establishing in our country. We refer to this as the [appropriate level of protection](#) (ALOP). We express Australia's ALOP as providing a high level of protection for human, animal and plant health aimed at reducing risk to a very low level, but not to zero. A zero-risk approach would mean Australia would have no imports at all.

Following the prioritisation of an [import request](#), we undertake an import risk analysis to determine if the good is safe to import. That is, we assess whether any biosecurity risks associated with the good can be managed to achieve Australia's ALOP.

If the risk cannot be managed effectively, we will not permit trade. If it can, we will require import conditions that importers must meet to import the good.

We may also undertake import risk analyses in response to new information, for example:

- technological advancements
- when there is a change in the level of biosecurity risk associated with the importation of the good.

How we undertake import risk analyses

We use a formal method to conduct import risk analyses. This method is consistent with international guidelines and the Biosecurity Act 2015. It includes a range of assessment tools, including a risk estimation matrix.

We assess the pests and diseases relevant to the imported good. Some of the factors we assess as part of the analysis include (but are not limited to) the:

- status of pests or diseases in the country of export, and Australia
- likelihood that pests or diseases will enter Australia on or in the imported good

- likelihood that pests or diseases will establish or spread in Australia
- potential consequences if pests or diseases were to establish and spread in Australia.

Under Australia's WTO obligations, we cannot consider the impact of market competition from imports. However, we do assess the potential economic consequences of pests and diseases establishing and spreading in Australia through imported products. This can include:

- costs of eradication and control
- impacts on domestic and international trade
- other significant economic effects.

We undertake standard import risk analyses or, in certain cases, a '[Biosecurity Import Risk Analysis \(BIRA\)](#)'. The situations where we undertake a BIRA may include:

- it is deemed appropriate by the Director of Biosecurity (the Secretary of the department) or the Minister for Agriculture, or
- relevant risk management measures
 - have not been established, or
 - exist for a similar good and pest or disease combination, but the likelihood and/or consequences of entry, establishment or spread of pests or diseases could differ significantly from those previously assessed.

Standard import risk analysis process

The standard risk analysis involves the following steps:

- Receive an [import market access request](#).
- Prioritise the import market access request.
- Announce the commencement of the import risk analysis and notify stakeholders.
- Publish an issues paper for public comment. This step is optional, and depends on the good being considered.
- Prepare a draft report after assessing the level of biosecurity risk and developing any proposed risk management measures.
- Publish the draft report for public consultation, which is generally for 60-calendar days. Stakeholders are notified and encouraged to provide feedback on the draft report. We meet with stakeholders in person and/or online during the consultation period, as required.
- Consider all comments received and prepare the final report.
- Publish the final report and notify stakeholders.

It may take anywhere from 18 months to 3 years to complete a standard risk analysis, depending on its complexity.

Biosecurity Import Risk Analysis process

The BIRA process involves additional requirements to our standard import risk analysis process, including:

- appointment of the [Scientific Advisory Group](#) to examine and provide comment on any aspect of the BIRA
- issuing a notice of intention to conduct a BIRA
- publishing an issues paper before releasing a draft report
- publishing a provisional report before releasing the final report
- an option for stakeholders to request the Inspector-General of Biosecurity (IGB) to review the process for conducting the analysis.

These steps are prescribed under the Biosecurity Act 2015 and the Biosecurity Regulations 2016.

Who we involve when undertaking import risk analyses

We seek input from relevant stakeholders for all import risk analyses, including BIRAs. This can include (but is not limited to) input from:

- industry stakeholders
- Commonwealth and state or territory government agencies
- Independent technical experts
- Stakeholders in the country of export
- for BIRAs, the [Scientific Advisory Group](#).

Throughout the risk analysis process, we notify and engage these stakeholders through:

- emails
- webpage updates
- issuing [Biosecurity Advices](#)
- [Have Your Say](#) survey (draft report stage)
- Virtual and face-to-face meetings (draft report stage and as needed)

Stakeholders can stay informed on all import risk analyses by [subscribing](#) to:

- ‘Biosecurity Risk Analysis Plant’
- ‘Biosecurity Risk Analysis Animal’.

Evidence informing our risk analyses

We use [information from various sources](#) to inform our risk analyses.

Trade implementation

Once we publish the final report, the import risk analysis process is complete. However, before imports can commence, we need to complete the following steps.

- In some cases, an import risk analysis may recommend that one of several equivalent measures can effectively manage the biosecurity risk posed by a pest or disease.
- In such instances, we confirm with the exporting country which measure they will use.
- We then develop import conditions for the commodity based on the final import risk analysis. These conditions may include:
 - pre-export requirements: what the competent authority in the exporting country must do before the good leaves the exporting country
 - on-arrival requirements: what Australia will do when the good reaches Australia's border
 - on-arrival outcomes: what will happen to the good after the completion of any on-arrival requirements.
- Prior to trade commencing we may require assurance from the competent authority in the exporting country that
 - the measures will be applied effectively, and
 - Australia's import requirements will be met.
- We obtain this assurance via a range of activities such as
 - visiting and auditing the exporting country
 - undertaking a desktop audit
 - requesting details of the exporting country's registered entities
 - bilateral agreements.
- We also consider a trading partner's compliance history when obtaining assurance and establishing arrangements for trade.
- Once we have drafted the import conditions and obtained assurance from the competent authority in the exporting country, we will publish the conditions on our Biosecurity Import Conditions system ([BICON](#)). We will also notify relevant stakeholders.
- Stakeholders can [register in BICON](#) to receive an alert when import conditions are published.
- Importers can apply for an import permit through BICON. Information on how to apply for an import permit is available on our website.
- The good will be considered a permitted good under the Biosecurity Act 2015.
- It can take anywhere from 3 months to several years after the final report has been published for import conditions to be published on BICON, allowing trade to commence.
- The decision to import the good is a commercial decision between an exporter in the exporting country and an importer in Australia who must meet our import conditions as set out in BICON.
- If trade does occur, we will monitor imports to verify that Australia's conditions are being met. We will take appropriate action where non-compliance is identified. Our biosecurity officers at the Australian border are key to ensuring that Australia's conditions are being met.

- We monitor for pests and diseases to ensure that the exporting country is meeting our import conditions. Where we find pests or diseases, we will take action at the Australian border to manage the biosecurity risk. This may include remedial management, or the re-export or destruction of the imported good. If the imported good is repeatedly non-compliant, the exporting country may be required to apply further measures, or we may suspend trade. Only when we have assurance that the risk can be managed will trade recommence. We obtain this assurance through a range of activities such as requiring the exporting country to investigate and report on the incident. We may visit and audit the exporting country.
- In addition to monitoring trade at the border, we undertake periodic verification of agreed offshore measures to ensure they continue to be applied effectively.
- We also regularly monitor new scientific information. We will review the import policy if there is information to suggest the biosecurity risk associated with the good has changed, or where alternative measures have become available.

Download

See our downloadable resources on the import risk analysis processes.

Source: <https://www.agriculture.gov.au/biosecurity-trade/policy/risk-analysis/undertaking-import-risk-analysis>